

Aftercare Instructions

How to look after your mouth after treatment at Bright Smile Dental

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Sample content: Bright Smile Dental is a fictional practice. This document was written for a software demonstration and is not medical advice.

About these aftercare instructions

These aftercare instructions explain how to look after your mouth after each treatment at Bright Smile Dental, what is normal while you heal, and the warning signs that mean you should contact the practice. Your dentist may give you extra instructions for your particular treatment. If your dentist's instructions are different from this document, follow your dentist's instructions.

If you have a problem after treatment, call Bright Smile Dental on +44 20 7946 0123 during opening hours (Monday to Friday, 9:00am to 5:00pm). When the practice is closed, call NHS 111. If you have swelling that affects your breathing or swallowing, or bleeding that will not stop, call 999 or go to your nearest A&E department.

Pain relief after dental treatment

Some discomfort after dental treatment is normal. Over-the-counter pain relief of the kind you would normally take for a headache is usually enough. Always follow the instructions on the packet and do not take more than the stated amount.

If you are not sure which pain relief is suitable for you, for example because you take other medicines, are pregnant, or have a medical condition, ask a pharmacist or your dentist before taking it. Bright Smile Dental's chat assistant cannot recommend medicines or doses.

Contact Bright Smile Dental if pain is getting worse instead of better after the first few days, or if pain relief is not controlling it.

Aftercare after a check-up and clean

After a check-up and clean, your teeth may feel slightly sensitive for a day or two, and your gums may bleed a little when you brush, especially if they were inflamed. This is normal and usually settles quickly.

Keep brushing twice a day with a fluoride toothpaste and cleaning between your teeth, even if your gums bleed. Bleeding gums usually improve with regular cleaning. If your gums are still bleeding after two weeks of careful brushing, mention it to the practice.

Aftercare after a dental filling

After a dental filling, your lip, cheek and tongue may stay numb for two to four hours.

While your mouth is still numb after a filling:

- Do not eat, so that you do not bite your cheek, lip or tongue without noticing.

- Avoid hot drinks, which could burn your mouth without you feeling it.
- Keep an eye on children, who may chew or suck their numb lip.

Once the numbness has worn off, you can eat and drink normally. Tooth-coloured composite fillings are fully hardened before you leave the practice.

What is normal after a filling: mild sensitivity to cold, hot or sweet things for a few weeks, and slight tenderness of the gum where the injection was given.

Contact Bright Smile Dental after a filling if:

- Your bite feels high or uneven once the numbness has gone. A high filling can make the tooth sore, and it is quick to adjust.
- Sensitivity is getting worse rather than better, or lasts longer than four weeks.
- You have a lasting throbbing pain, or pain that keeps you awake.
- The filling feels rough, cracked or has come out.

Aftercare after root canal treatment

After root canal treatment, the tooth often feels tender for a few days, especially when you bite on it. This tenderness should improve a little each day.

To look after a tooth after root canal treatment:

- Do not eat until the numbness has worn off.
- Avoid chewing hard or sticky food on the treated tooth until the dentist has placed the permanent filling or crown. A tooth that has had root canal treatment is more likely to break before it is fully restored.
- If you have a temporary filling between visits, it is normal for a small amount to wear away. Contact the practice if the whole temporary filling falls out.
- Keep brushing and cleaning around the tooth as normal.
- Attend the appointment for your permanent filling or crown. Delaying it increases the risk of the tooth breaking or becoming reinfected.

Contact Bright Smile Dental after root canal treatment if you have swelling inside or outside the mouth, pain that is getting worse after the first two to three days, a temporary filling that has fallen out, or a reaction such as a rash or itching.

Aftercare after a tooth extraction: the first 24 hours

The first 24 hours after a tooth extraction are the most important for healing. A blood clot forms in the empty socket, and protecting this clot helps the socket heal and prevents dry socket.

For the first 24 hours after a tooth extraction:

- Keep the gauze pad in place, biting firmly, for 20 to 30 minutes after you leave the practice.
- Do not rinse your mouth, so that the blood clot is not washed away.
- Do not smoke or vape. Smoking greatly increases the risk of dry socket.
- Do not drink through a straw, because the sucking can pull out the clot.
- Do not drink alcohol.

- Avoid hot food and hot drinks, and do not eat until the numbness has worn off.
- Avoid hard exercise for the rest of the day.
- Rest with your head raised on an extra pillow on the first night.
- Do not poke the socket with your tongue or fingers.

Aftercare after a tooth extraction: if the socket bleeds

A little oozing of blood, or pink saliva, is normal for the first day after a tooth extraction.

If the socket starts to bleed after a tooth extraction:

1. Roll up a clean cotton handkerchief or a piece of gauze and place it over the socket.
2. Bite down on it firmly for 20 minutes without checking it. Sit upright and stay calm.
3. If bleeding continues, repeat with a fresh pad for another 20 minutes.

If heavy bleeding has not stopped after two rounds of firm pressure, contact Bright Smile Dental during opening hours or call NHS 111 when the practice is closed. If bleeding is heavy and you feel faint or unwell, call 999 or go to A&E.

Aftercare after a tooth extraction: the days after

From the day after a tooth extraction:

- Gently rinse your mouth with warm salty water after meals, made with half a teaspoon of salt in a glass of warm water. Do this for about a week. Let the water fall out of your mouth rather than spitting forcefully.
- Brush your teeth as normal but be gentle near the socket.
- Eat soft food and chew on the other side of your mouth for a few days.
- Keep not smoking for as long as possible, ideally for at least 72 hours.

Swelling and stiffness of the jaw are normal and are usually worst on the second or third day after a tooth extraction, then improve. Bruising may also appear. Dissolving stitches usually disappear within one to two weeks.

Dry socket after a tooth extraction

Dry socket is a painful condition that can happen after a tooth extraction when the blood clot is lost or does not form properly, leaving the bone in the socket exposed.

Signs of dry socket:

- Pain that gets worse two to four days after the extraction, instead of better.
- Pain that spreads towards the ear on the same side.
- A bad taste or bad smell from the mouth.
- An empty-looking socket where you cannot see a blood clot.

If you think you have dry socket, contact Bright Smile Dental. Dry socket is not dangerous, but it is painful and the dentist can clean the socket and place a soothing dressing to relieve the pain.

Aftercare after dental implant surgery

Aftercare after dental implant surgery is similar to aftercare after a tooth extraction. Follow all of the first-24-hour instructions for a tooth extraction, including not rinsing, not smoking and not using straws.

In addition, after dental implant surgery:

- Swelling and bruising are common and are usually worst on the second or third day. A cold pack wrapped in a cloth, held against the cheek for ten minutes at a time on the first day, can help.
- Eat soft food and avoid chewing on the implant site until the dentist says it is safe.
- If you have a temporary denture, wear it only as the dentist has instructed, so that it does not press on the implant while it heals.
- Keep the area clean with gentle warm salty water rinses from the day after surgery.
- Stitches are either dissolving or removed at a review appointment about one to two weeks after surgery.
- Do not smoke. Smoking is one of the main reasons dental implants fail to bond with the bone.

Contact Bright Smile Dental after implant surgery if swelling is still increasing after three days, you have a fever, the implant feels loose, or pain is getting worse instead of better.

Aftercare after teeth whitening

The most common effect after teeth whitening is sensitivity, especially to cold. Sensitivity after teeth whitening usually settles within a few days.

To manage sensitivity after teeth whitening:

- Use a toothpaste for sensitive teeth for two weeks before and after whitening.
- Avoid very hot or very cold food and drinks for a few days.
- If sensitivity is uncomfortable, contact the practice for advice.

For the first 48 hours after teeth whitening, teeth pick up stains more easily. During this time, avoid strongly coloured food and drink such as coffee, tea, red wine, cola, curry, tomato sauce, berries and soy sauce, and do not smoke. This is often called a white diet.

What is normal and when to contact us

Symptom	Normal for	Contact Bright Smile Dental if
Numbness	2 to 4 hours after local anaesthetic	It lasts into the next day
Sensitivity to cold	A few weeks after a filling; a few days after whitening	It is getting worse or lasts more than 4 weeks
Tenderness when biting	A few days after root canal treatment	It is getting worse after 3 days
Oozing or pink saliva	The first day after an extraction	Bleeding is heavy and does not stop with pressure
Swelling	Up to 3 days after an extraction or implant surgery	It keeps increasing after 3 days, or you have a fever
Pain	A few days after an extraction	It gets worse 2 to 4 days after the extraction

Get emergency help straight away by calling 999 or going to A&E if swelling affects your breathing or swallowing, swelling spreads to your eye or neck, or bleeding is heavy and will not stop.